

KF13 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we are looking at KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

In recent lessons we have been using mindfulness training to explore our legal systems. We create legal systems because we are afraid of something. We think that these laws will help us feel safe in a chaotic world. Through the **SALT Process**, you are learning to examine your legal systems by identifying an area of your life that you have judged as evil. You are also learning to look at the fear behind your judgment.

Training is always somewhat difficult because you have to tear down what you have previously built so that you can build something new. If you struggle with the mindfulness training, observe the struggle without judgment and simply allow it to be. You are building new brain pathways, and that is hard work. Your endurance gives those new brain paths time to grow. It takes a great deal of effort to forge a new path through the jungle of your mind, so think of yourself as an explorer carving out a new path toward mindfulness. Later in your training, you might increase your meditation time to twenty minutes, twice each day. You are creating a new habitat where you will be able to remain peaceful, observe without judgment, know what is *your business*, and have a real choice as to how you will speak and act.

Let’s continue to practice the **SALT Process**.

1. S is for Skin

Assume a mindfulness posture. *(Pause)* Focus your mind on your body, and breathe. Feel the air move in and out. *(Pause)* Notice where your skin is. Perhaps you can feel the air or clothing on your skin. Notice how your skin provides a delineation between what is outside and what is inside. Your skin is a physical boundary. *(Pause)* Now, guide your attention to observe only what is within your skin, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. A is for Assess

Allow an event or situation to come to mind, one that you have judged as evil. Observe how your body

feels when you think of that event or situation. *(Pause)* Is there tension, fatigue, restlessness, or something you cannot describe? Where in your body do you feel those sensations? *(Pause)* On a scale of one to ten, assess the intensity of what you are feeling. *(Pause)* If you feel discomfort that is too distracting for you, use the Dragon Breath to dissipate the tension, breathing loudly and powerfully from your diaphragm. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. L is for Look

Look for the fear. Ask yourself and ask God: *What frightens my Idol Self about this event or situation? What seems to undermine my search for glory?* *(Pause)* Step back from judging the event and simply look at the fear behind the judgment. Observing the fear brings you valuable information about yourself and is part of your healing process. *(Pause)* You might try welcoming the fear and thanking it for what it is telling you about the quality of your faith, or trust in God. Thank the fear for its part in motivating you to grow. As you thank the fear, use a long exhaling breath, like a sigh. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. T is for Tell

Tell God about the fear. Talk to Him about what frightens you and about the stories that you use to justify your fear. *(Pause)* Are your stories about the past or the future, about others, or about yourself? *(Pause)* Ask God to tell you the truth about this situation that frightens you and to replace the fear with the positive motivations of hope, trust, and love. Offer Him gratitude. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause, and take a few relaxing breaths. You may wish to take a sip of water and jot down a few notes about what you have learned, or you might simply rest in the stillness for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

As you rest, listen to our hymn for this confession, *All the Way my Savior Leads Me*.

All the way my Savior leads me, cheers each winding path I tread,
Gives me grace for every trial, feeds me with the living Bread.
Though my weary steps may falter, and my soul athirst may be,
Gushing from the Rock before me—Lo! A spring of joy I see;
Gushing from the Rock before me—Lo! A spring of joy I see.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

The **Two Paths Flowchart** begins with an event. Right now we are concerned with events that trigger a fear reaction. If we perceive the event as a danger or a threat to our Idol Self, we judge it as evil. If the event delivers us from that perceived danger, we judge it as good. *The judgment, however, more than the event, is the real problem. (Repeat)*

We are so afraid of messing up, of others messing up, or of life messing up according to our ideas of good or evil, and yet these feelings of fear are not evil in themselves—the fear of lost opportunity and potential may actually motivate us to do the work of recovery. You can learn to recognize fear in your body whenever you feel strain, the need to force your reality, the craving to run away, the urge to appease, or the need to control, undermine, attack, or play the victim. Even if you can't name your fear, you can take the Believe It Path instead of reacting on autopilot like a silly rabbit that runs into the hunter's snare. As you work through the **Two Paths Worksheet**, you are training yourself to ask: *Do I want to take the Judgment Path or the Believe It Path?* Just by asking yourself that question, you choose to disengage from autopilot and refuse to be unwittingly driven into slavery by your fear; you pause and consciously choose to endure the tension of saying no to fear while you train to achieve a healthier outcome.

Unexamined fear tricks you into taking the Judgment Path over and over again. In KF, you are learning to recognize misoriented fear for what it is—simply a habitual physical reaction triggered by unprocessed trauma. Exchange your fear for wonder. Practice using the energy devoted to your fear to develop your faith, or your trust, in God and in His design. As you develop your trust, you will become less and less fearful and spend less of your life on autopilot.

As I've mentioned before, your faith or trust is your business, and learning to trust is your responsibility. You cannot depend on anyone else to learn and exercise faith for you. However, you will need training. Training means that you submit to a program for a time until you can learn to productively direct yourself. Training gives you vision for what is possible, and it helps you develop the skills and resources required to achieve that vision.

The Idol Self would have you believe that you can tackle all kinds of situations, relationships, or work, without training or effort. It even tells you that God makes things happen for you without your participation. Like magic, you should be able to manage every situation heroically. It's crazy! The Idol wants you to believe that you will magically know how to be a husband or wife, how to parent, how to contribute and circulate, how to handle your fears, how to live an authentic Christian life full of the Fruit of the Spirit, how to take care of yourself, and how to give of yourself—and all that without any need for training or developed endurance. The Idol cannot tolerate being a mere mortal in need of training. Everyone needs training in everything, and Karis Fellowships is one of the many programs available to help you train.

Your business is to get training, but the Idol Self is against you doing your business, so you may actively distract yourself from that pursuit. You may have been trained to take on business that is not actually yours. You may think that your business is to find someone else to take care of you. You may try to control other people's business. You may have opted out of your business in an effort to escape circulating in accordance with your design. You may hoard and avoid making any personal contribution to your community.

Working on your business may feel loathsome for a little while, and that's why the effort you make to deal with your business is another way of losing your life for Christ's sake. You have to exercise some self-discipline to take up your training, and then, with a little practice, you can start using your new skills to help you withstand your habitual motivations of euphoria and fear. As you take responsibility for your own life, you will naturally turn away from magical thinking and begin to build a real life in this material world; you will learn to submit to the limitation that your business has to be done in this world and can only be done by you. That worthwhile and rewarding process requires endurance and cooperation with God's training as He works to bring you into your real glory and potential.

The **Two Paths Worksheet** trains you to take the path of love, which leads to oriented outcomes. It teaches you how to untangle the jumble of judgments, thoughts, and feelings that are often triggered by life's events and people's choices. When you practice the Believe It Path, you learn not only to recognize your business but to manage your business and to stop wasting your energy on unproductive judging.

Next week, we will look at the **Shoulds Worksheet**. Print out a copy for your KF ring binder and explore it this week, perhaps with your Karis Link.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, help me take up the work of my business. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's look again at the first chapter of James.

In our last lesson, we learned from James that the deceitful gifts of the hunter harm us, while God's gifts rebirth us into our design and potential. If we are to courageously reject the hunter's gifts, we must have vision for what God's gifts can do. Hopefully, through KF, you are catching a glimpse of that vision.

Let's read my translation of James 1:18.

¹⁸God never intended death to be the harvest of these times of trial; rather, it is His intention to produce our True Selves by the creative process and the first principle of truth so that we would be a kind of firstfruits among His creatures.

What does it mean to be firstfruits? It means that we, in Christ, have become something completely new. We are a new family expressing the Person and character of God, our Father, in a way that the world has not yet experienced.² Later in this chapter, James teaches us that in order to become those firstfruits, we have to take responsibility for our business. Let's take a minute to expand our understanding of the Greek word *logos*, which we touched on in the **KF Introductory Meeting**. Logos can be translated as *word*, but it can also be accurately translated as *God's way of doing things*. Jesus was the Logos; He showed us how to do things God's way. It is our business to get rid of all those things that interfere with our ability both to receive and to bind ourselves to the logos.

Here is my paraphrase of **James 1:21–25**.

²¹Therefore, wiping away all filthiness and all that remains of cowardice, in humility receive the logos implanted, which is able to rescue your True Self. ²²Become doers of the logos and not just hearers who will not evaluate themselves accurately; ²³because if anyone is a hearer of the logos and not a doer, that person is only an image, an illusion, and is revealed to be the kind of person who only glances at the logos as they would glance into a mirror simply to see their natural face. ²⁴How do we know that? Because

once that illusion-person has compared themselves to the logos and gone away, they immediately forget what kind of person they actually are. ²⁵But the one who makes an effort to lean on the logos, which is the fulfilling law of real freedom, and works to remain near it—not having become a forgetful hearer, but an effortful doer—that person will be happy and favored in all of their doing.

Take a deep breath.

Earlier in this chapter, James taught us that we are lured by the hunter, or get into the wrong pasture, because of our cravings and greed. We learned that the outcome of those cravings is death. James contrasts the outcome of death with the creative principle of God's way of doing things—the logos—which leads to life. That life begins when we are finally willing to see ourselves as we actually are, but we can't do that until we get rid of all the stuff that is clouding, muddying, and interfering with an honest self-evaluation. We need to clean the mirror. By doing so, we get into the right pasture and are then able to humbly accept the logos, God's way of doing things. When we embrace God's way, our True Self is rescued, and we are granted a place of favor in our karis relationship with Him.

Our business is to practice what we learn and become doers of the logos, but, like all learners, we will make mistakes and be inconsistent. We can't do it all, all of the time, and right now. So, as you explore your KF tools, I'd like to encourage you to find the ones that work for you. You are presently collecting tools and exploring how helpful they might be. Choose a tool and use it for a few weeks, and then set it aside while you practice another one. Return to the tools that work for you. We are like small children learning to walk. We are on a path of discovery, and the mirror of the logos is our friend.

You can discover who you really are by looking into the mirror of your life. This mirror reflects the outcomes of your choices, and those outcomes reveal to you, and to others, whether you are on the Believe It Path or the Judgment Path. If you are not committed to true evidence, you will forget that your outcomes are the result of your choices, and you will make up virtue stories. Virtue stories are stories that we tell ourselves and others about the marvelous reasons why we do what we do, feel what we feel, and have what we have. Virtue stories support our pride system and allow our Idol Self to go on living in its illusions, conveniently forgetting that our outcomes reveal the truth about who we are and what we, as powerful human creatures, have chosen.

Once we have reoriented to God's design and His logos, we can begin training with endurance to live more thoroughly in the law of real freedom. The desired outcome is that we are more effective in this world and able to experience great and real happiness. We learn to live in the freedom of who we were created to be. Our oriented choices, our ability to confidently stand firm, and our blessed outcomes reveal the evidence of who we really are in Christ. They teach the world what God intended for all of us.

What is this law of freedom? James explains it further in chapter 2. It is the principle of cause and effect. The outcome or effect of doing the logos is a productive and blessed life. We ourselves are always the cause of our life's outcomes. With mindful choices, we can learn to become the cause of our own liberty and blessing. How does James describe it? The law of freedom is the logos, and the logos is described as *telos*, which is often translated as *perfect*. *Telos* has nothing to do with the Idol's compulsive need to achieve its illusions of perfection. *Telos* is the fulfillment of a designed purpose. Your designed purpose is to grow in the logos and learn how to live in this law of real freedom. If you are in that process, you are fulfilling the logos and are, therefore, perfect or *telos*. As a doer of the logos in your own life, you are learning to become the cause that influences this world. James presents perfection as the freedom to

fulfill your design according to the logos, unhampered by the Idol and its compulsive needs. Thomas Sterner in his book *The Practicing Mind* offers a metaphor that describes the perfection of a growing thing that fulfills its created design at every stage of its development. He writes:

As we attempt to understand ourselves and our struggles with life's endeavors, we may find peace in the observation of a flower. Ask yourself: *At what point in a flower's life, from seed to full bloom, does it reach perfection?*³ (Repeat) (Pause)

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord of the law of freedom, help me be a perfect doer of the logos at whatever stage I am. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider an area of your life where you might choose to do things God's way. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider an area of your life where you might choose to do things God's way*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider an area of your life where you might choose to do things God's way. (Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing as you *consider this area of your life where you might choose to do things God's way*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what resistance or the fear of losing control feels like in your body, or perhaps what courage or trustworthiness feels like. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your

attention to another area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, respectfully return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this area of your life where you might choose to do things God's way*. Are you comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge this area as good or scary? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is this experience a regular pattern in your life? Are you afraid of something—of loss, of others, of deprivation—or perhaps you are afraid of your true glory? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created you to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you do when they have *considered choosing to do things God's way*. You are a human creature and are not alone in your feelings. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with those feelings. *(Pause)* You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for everyone who is making the effort to live by the logos. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time together to heal and train. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to the truth about our glory and about ourselves. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *All the Way My Savior Leads Me* by Fanny J. Crosby (1820–1915), www.youtube.com/watch?v=ekUELQnCnQIM.

² 1 Pet. 2:9.

³ Thomas Sterner, *The Practicing Mind: Developing Focus and Discipline in Your Life—Master Any Skill or Challenge by Learning to Love the Process* (Novato: New World Library, 2012), 42.